

1992–95 **Trials of prodemocracy** activists continue. Plans for market economy accelerated.

1993 **Jiang Zemin replaces** Yang Shangkun as president, espousing the policy of a “Socialist Market Economy.”

1995–96 **Chinese missile tests** in the Strait of Taiwan lead to serious crisis and allegations that China is seeking to influence the results of the 1996 Taiwanese presidential elections.

1997 **Deng Xiaoping** dies at age 92. The UK hands back sovereignty over Hong Kong to China. The five-yearly party congress confirms Jiang’s leadership and backs his reformist policies.

1998 **Zhu Rongji** becomes prime minister and announces economic reforms that will lead to the closure or amalgamation of loss-making state enterprises and a reduction in the civil service by up to 4 million jobs. The East Asian economic crisis leads to a sharp downturn in growth, but China avoids significant capital flight or currency devaluation.

1999 **The Portuguese-administered** territory of Macao is returned to China. There is friction over a Taiwanese claim of statehood. NATO accidentally bombs the Chinese embassy in Belgrade leading to international crisis. The quasi-religious Falun Gong sect is declared a threat to stability and outlawed.

2000 **Taiwanese presidential election** causes tension. US normalizes trade relations. As part of an official clampdown on corruption, a former deputy chairman of the National People’s Congress is executed for accepting a bribe.

2001 **Major diplomatic** incident with US when a Chinese pilot is killed and a US spy-plane is forced down on Hainan Island. China carries out military exercises simulating an invasion of Taiwan. Beijing is awarded the 2008 Olympic Games. China joins the World Trade Organization after a 15-year campaign to secure its entry to the world trading body.

2002 **Vice President Hu Jintao** becomes Head of the CCP, replacing Jiang Zemin. US President George W. Bush visits China on the 30th anniversary of the visit by his predecessor Richard Nixon.

2003 **Outbreak of** Severe Acute Respiratory Syndrome (SARS) in China. The extremely infectious disease spreads throughout East and Southeast Asia and as far as Europe and the US, sparking concerns about a global pandemic and leaving nearly 800 dead before the outbreak is contained. Hu Jintao is elected as president by the National People’s Congress. China’s first manned spacecraft is launched, with astronaut Yang Liwei on board. Construction begins on the Three Gorges Dam on the Yangtze River.

2004 **China signs** economic agreement with Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) trading bloc.

CHINA

SPECIAL ADMINISTRATIVE REGIONS AND DISPUTED TERRITORIES

HONG KONG ISLAND was ceded to Britain in 1842. Further mainland territory was acquired in 1860 (the Kowloon peninsula) and 1898 (the New Territories). Hong Kong was returned to Chinese rule in 1997.

- 1842** The UK defeats China in the Opium War of 1839–42; as a result, Hong Kong is ceded to the UK under the Treaty of Nanjing.
- 1860** Defeat in the Second Opium War (1856–60) leads to cession of Kowloon.
- 1898** Continued aggression pressures the Manchu government to sign the second Peking Convention, granting a 99-year lease of the New Territories to the UK.
- 1941–45** The Japanese invade and occupy Hong Kong.
- 1949** The communist takeover of mainland China halts British plans to allow greater autonomy to Hong Kong.
- 1967** Hong Kong trade is disrupted by civil disturbances created by the influence of the Cultural Revolution in China.
- 1981** The British Nationality Act, granting British Nationality (Overseas) but not right of abode in the UK to Hong Kong Chinese creates great controversy.
- 1984** The Sino-British Joint Declaration is signed. It grants China sovereignty over Hong Kong after 1997, guaranteeing a high degree of autonomy in economic affairs and the continuation of the present legal and capitalist economic systems.
- 1997** Hong Kong handed back to China, now known as a Special Administrative Region of China.
- 2008** Prodemocracy parties win more than a third of seats, giving them veto over constitutional changes.

- MACAO** occupies a narrow peninsula on the opposite side of the Pearl River estuary from Hong Kong. The last European colony in Asia, Macao was handed back to China by Portugal in 1999.
- 1513** The first Portuguese ship arrives in the Pearl River estuary.
- 1557** Portugal begins paying tribute to China in return for using Macau as an intermediary port for ships traveling to Japan. An international merchant community establishes itself.
- 1800s** Hong Kong replaces Macau as the major trading port of the region.
- 1955** Macau is made an overseas province by Portugal.
- 1984** For the first time, the Chinese majority are given the vote.
- 1987** Portugal agrees to return Macau to China in 1999 on terms similar to those agreed with the UK over Hong Kong.
- 1999** Macau becomes a Special Administrative Region of China.

TAIWAN The island lies off the southeast coast of mainland China. Mountains cover two-thirds of the island. The fertile lowlands are densely populated. In 1949, when the communists ousted Chiang Kai-shek’s Kuomintang (KMT) from power on the mainland, he established the Republic of China on the island. De facto military rule has been democratized progressively since 1986, and the KMT’s grip was shaken by defeat in the 2000 presidential election. Mainland China still considers Taiwan a renegade province, and only a few countries officially recognize the regime there.

- 1590** Portuguese sailors reach the island and name it Formosa (beautiful).
- 1642** The Dutch take control.
- 1683** The Manchus claim the island as part of Qing China.
- 1895** Following China’s defeat in the Sino-Japanese War, control of the island passes to Japan.
- 1945** Taiwan is returned to China.
- 1949** Chiang Kai-shek establishes the Republic of China on the island.
- 1971** The People’s Republic of China replaces Taiwan at the UN.
- 1975** Chiang Kai-shek dies. His son Chiang Ching-kuo becomes KMT leader.
- 1986** KMT ends martial law and permits visits to the Chinese mainland for “humanitarian” purposes for first time in 38 years. In 1988, mainland Chinese are allowed to visit Taiwan on same basis. Formation of political parties is permitted.
- 1990** KMT formally ends its state of war with People’s Republic of China.
- 1996** Lee Teng-hui wins first direct presidential elections.
- 1999** Thousands die in earthquake.
- 2000** Chen Shui-bian of DPP wins presidency, overturning KMT dominance.
- 2003** Taipei 101, the world’s tallest building, is completed. There is a severe outbreak of the viral disease SARS.
- 2005** Lien Chan becomes the first KMT leader since 1949 to visit mainland China.
- 2008** The KMT wins a landslide victory in parliamentary elections. Ma Ying-Jeou of the KMT is elected president. Former president Chen is arrested on charges of money laundering.
- 2010** China and Taiwan sign free trade pact.

2005 **First direct** flights between People’s Republic of China and Taiwan since 1949. Violent anti-Japanese protests break out in Chinese cities over the coverage of Japan’s occupation of China in a Japanese school textbook. Lien Chian, chairman of the Kuomintang party of Taiwan, visits mainland China and meets CCP leader Hu Jintao, the highest-level meeting between Beijing and Taipei politicians since 1949. China and Russia hold first joint military exercises. The highly pathogenic H5N1 strain of avian flu is detected in migratory birds in Qinghai, China. China and Russia sign an agreement settling a long-running dispute over their common eastern border.

- Former reformist leader Zhao Ziyang dies after years of house arrest following the Tiananmen Square massacre.
- 2006** **Work on the** Three Gorges Dam is finished. A railway line linking China and Tibet is completed. The official news agency announces the worst drought in 50 years.
- 2007** **China carries out** a successful missile test in space, destroying a Chinese weather satellite. Prime Minister Wen Jiabao addresses the Japanese parliament, the first Chinese head of government to do so, as the two countries agree to a process of reconciliation.

- 2008** **A huge earthquake** in Sichuan kills tens of thousands; China and Russia sign a treaty to end their 40-year border dispute; Beijing hosts the Olympic Games. A scandal erupts as 50,000 Chinese children fall ill after drinking tainted milk.
- 2009** **China and Russia** sign a 20-year deal to supply oil to China. Serious ethnic disturbances erupt in Xinjiang.
- 2010** **Imprisoned Chinese dissident** Liu Xiaobao is awarded the Nobel Peace Prize.

- «60–61 **Bronze Age China**
- «126–27 **The Unification of China**
- «128–29 **The Centralized State**
- «160–61 **China’s Golden Age**
- «162–63 **The Song Dynasty**
- «166–67 **The Ming Dynasty**
- «184–85 **The Silk Road**
- «240–41 **The Three Emperors**
- «354–55 **The Opium Wars**
- «424–25 **China’s Long March**
- «472–73 **Superpower China**

Hong Kong is returned to China
On July 1, 1997, Hong Kong (left) reverted from British to Chinese sovereignty. Under the policy of “one country, two systems,” the island remains a center of international finance and trade.

